crossings and provided ration for four days before receiving renewed assistance in camps.[51] Before makeshift camps came up, public schools and educational institutions served as stopgap arrangements as they were closed for the summer vacations in April and May. In West Bengal, the Central Relief Office of Calcutta provided the tarpaulin and plastic sheets while locally available bamboo was used to erect camps. Numerous welfare groups in India joined in the effort, buoyed by a call towards national duty. The Marwari Relief Society, based in Calcutta, had over fifty years of experience in relief work, including significant roles during the Burmese crisis and the 1947 Partition. The ‘parasites’, as Bengali nationalist P.C. Ray had once mockingly called them, ran ten relief camps in Basirhat with over 3,00,000 Bengali-speaking refugees.

A pressing concern in the camps was the procurement of adequate supplies of essential commodities. By one estimate, 5,80,000 tonnes of rice were required to feed 6 million refugees for six months. India’s refugee problem was larger than that. Existing stocks were depleted and replenished by food aid from other countries. New depots of the Food Corporation of India (FCI) were set up to distribute food rations. This helped curtail the rising pressure on prices of essential commodities along India’s eastern border. Similarly, medical store depots were regularly stocked and re-stocked, and public health personnel were moved to the border areas to contain potential epidemics that may have broken out from the camps. Cholera had claimed the lives of over 5000 refugees until September 1971, and the danger of a public health disaster loomed large. Water tankers were arranged for distributing water, tubewells were sunk and thousands of latrines were constructed. Volunteer groups conducted educational lectures for children in the camps, while separate women’s homes and orphanages were also set up. The central government financed refugee assistance and sought aid from outside. As the refugee influx overwhelmed India’s districts along the borders, the Indian legislature discussed ways to move the refugees to other states. The uncertainty over the period of stay and the size of the influx led to heated debates. In the end, a few of the 800-odd camps